

COUNT TO 15, THEN ANSWER ANY PRODUCT QUESTION

How Would You Get a New Account Its First 1,000 Followers?

Dennis · Sr PM at Microsoft · @dennisthinks_

1 Buy time, then count to 15

Tell the interviewer you're taking a moment, then breathe and count to 15 in your head. Do it even if you already know how you'd start. Use the count to decide what you'd ask first.

EXAMPLE

"Give me a few seconds to think this through."

When you hit 15, don't start designing. Ask your questions.

2 Ask clarifying questions

For a design question, ask three to five. Pick the ones that change your answer the most. "A new account" could mean a person, a small business, or a creator. "Followers" could mean anyone, or people who actually watch.

EXAMPLE

"Is this a person, a small business, or a creator? Do the followers need to engage, or does any follower count? Is this a product feature or advice for the account?"

Repeat their answer back before you move on: "Got it, a feature for new creators, and the goal is getting them to 1,000 real followers without quitting."

3 Break it apart on paper

Write the question at the top of the page and split it into layers before you pick anything. Go from who, to what bugs them, to ideas. Don't pick a fix yet.

EXAMPLE

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First 1,000 followers for new creators
├ Users: new creators, small businesses, restarted accounts
│   └ What's stopping them: _____
│       └ Ideas for each one: _____
│           └ The one you pick: _____
│               └ How you'd measure it: _____
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Fill in the blanks out loud. Turn the page toward the interviewer so they can follow along.

4 Work it top down

Go one layer at a time and say why at every step. Name the user, the pain point, three ideas, then pick one.

EXAMPLE

1. Start with new creators. They post the most and quit the fastest when nobody shows up.
User: new creators
2. Say the problem is their first posts reach almost nobody, so they never learn if their content works.
Pain point: first posts reach almost nobody
3. Three ideas: show a new creator's first 10 posts to a small test audience, suggest them to people who follow similar accounts, and a starter checklist for the profile.
Ideas: test audience, similar-account suggestions, profile checklist
4. Pick the test audience. Real feedback on the first 10 posts tells creators what works before they give up.
Pick: first 10 posts shown to a small test audience
5. Say how you'd measure it. If it works, more new creators reach 1,000 followers and keep posting.
Metric: new creators at 1,000 followers and still posting at 90 days

If they push back on your user or pain point, take theirs and keep going.

5 Check it with the interviewer

You can't run user research in the room, so the interviewer is your user. Say your pick and ask if it's the direction they want. They'll agree, push on a corner case, or point you somewhere else. Answer the corner case, then give a rough cost and time to build.

EXAMPLE

You: "I'd show a new creator's first 10 posts to a small group of people who like that topic. Does that direction work?"

Interviewer: "What stops spammers from making new accounts to get the boost?"

You: "The boost only starts after a phone number check and a few days of normal use. Another corner case: the test audience gets tired of beginners, so each viewer sees only a few new-creator posts a day. It uses the feed we already have, so a small team could test it in about 2 months."

Interviewer: "Good."

If they point you somewhere else, don't defend your first pick. Go back to your tree, take the next idea, and run it through the same checks.

Practice on this one

Set a 10-minute timer, have a friend play the interviewer, and record it. Run all five steps out loud, count included. Play it back and flag anything you decided without saying why.

☐ Should Instagram hide follower counts?

Score every answer

Use this checklist after each practice run:

- ☐ Did I say "give me a few seconds" and count to 15?
- ☐ Did I ask three to five clarifying questions and repeat the goal back?
- ☐ Did I sketch users, pain points and ideas on paper before picking?
- ☐ Did I pick one idea and say why?
- ☐ Did I handle the interviewer's corner case and give a rough cost and time?
- ☐ Did I say how I'd measure it?